SCRIPT: Amazon Alone

Story Map version: 5 · Deslopped

Revised: B01, B08, B09, B11, B15, B16 (Story Map v5 and the creator's approved fixes)

[B01]

Twenty minutes. That's how long the walk was supposed to take. Nobody would come looking for you before dark.

A marked loop into the forest behind a river lodge in the Brazilian Amazon, a few hours by boat from the city of Manaus. Back before dark, the staff said. Two long wooden boats knock against the dock as you set off at dusk. You go alone, in trail shoes, with your phone and a half-full plastic water bottle. Nothing else. No lighter. No knife.

The safety talk on your first night covered snakes, and the things not to do. You half listened. The animal on your mind for three days has been a jaguar. Part of you hopes to see one, from the safety of a boat. Part of you checks the trees every time something moves.

[B02]

The path is easy at first. Red mud, roots worn smooth, little painted marks on the trunks. The light is already going green and thin.

Then, off to your left, something heavy breaks through the undergrowth. Not a bird. Not a monkey. Branches snap. Leaves shake. It's close, and it's big, and it doesn't stop.

Your mind fills in the rest before you can think. Spotted coat. Low shoulders. Teeth.

You run.

Not down the path. Away from the sound, straight into the trees, because that's where your legs take you. Leaves whip your face. The bottle bangs against your hip. Somewhere behind you the crashing stops, or maybe you just can't hear it over your own breathing.

[B03]

A minute. Maybe two. That's all it is.

Something catches your left shin mid-stride, a broken branch or a spiny stem, and pulls. It doesn't hurt yet. It just feels hot.

When you finally stop and bend over, gasping, the shin is wet and dark. A long cut, ragged at one end, running down toward your sock.

You straighten up and turn to go back to the path.

There is no path.

Trunks in every direction. Vines. Palms with long spines on their stems. The same green-grey wall wherever you look, and the light draining out of it. You turn a full circle,

slowly, and nothing looks like the way you came.

You pull out your phone. No signal. Not one bar.

[B04]

The dark comes faster than you expected.

You could keep moving. The path has to be close. But in this light you can't see the ground, and the ground is roots, holes and those spined palms. A fall, a twisted ankle, a branch through the eye: any of those turns a bad night into something much worse.

Something you read once comes back, half-remembered. If you're lost, stop.

So you stop. You find the widest trunk nearby and put your back against it. At least nothing can come at you from behind.

[B05]

You shout first. "Hello!" Then louder. Then the lodge's name, again and again, until your throat burns.

Nothing answers except insects, millions of them, and then rain.

You hear it before you feel it, a roar spreading across the canopy far above you like applause. A lot of it never gets down to you. The leaves catch it. What does arrive comes in fat, heavy drops, splattering off leaves the size of plates.

You unscrew the bottle and hold it out. It fills slowly, drop by drop. You drink some. It's warm and tastes of leaves, and it's the best thing you've ever had.

Then you look at the shin.

With the phone's light you can see it properly: dirt in the cut, a sliver of bark near the top. You pour a little rainwater over it and pick the bark out with your fingernails. Then you tear a strip off the bottom of your sleeve and tie it around your leg. It isn't clean. It isn't a dressing. It's what you have.

The phone goes off to save the battery.

The rain keeps coming. You're soaked through, shirt, socks and shoes, but it isn't cold. It's warm, and that somehow makes it worse. There's no shivering to keep you busy. Just wet, and dark, and sounds. Mosquitoes whine at your ears, and every few minutes one finds your neck or your wrist. A rustle. A drip. Something that might be breathing, or might be you.

And just like that, the jaguar is back. Low shoulders. Spotted coat. Somewhere out there in the black, close enough to hear you breathe. You press your back into the tree until the bark hurts, and you stay like that, rigid, listening, for what feels like hours.

You don't sleep. Not really.

[B06]

Morning arrives as a dim green glow, as if the forest were slowly turning its lamps on.

Under the strip, the cut is still angry at the edges, a pink-red rim around it, and it stings when the air touches it. Could be healing. Could be something else. You tie the strip back on.

Your shoes squelch. They haven't dried and they're not going to. The phone won't turn on at all. The rain got into it in the night.

But it's daylight, and daylight changes things. You only ran for a minute or two. The path can't be more than a few hundred steps away. You just need to walk in a straight line, and you'll hit it.

You pick a direction, the one that feels most like the way you came, and go. Every few steps you snap a sapling, bending it over so the pale inside shows. If you need to come back, you'll follow your own trail.

You stop shouting. It hurts your throat and makes you thirsty, and by lunch you'll be eating at the lodge anyway.

[B07]

After an hour, the trail of snapped saplings stretches behind you and the forest ahead looks exactly the same. Same trunks. Same vines. Same green half-light.

You're watching the ground for the path when you see it.

A snake, coiled in the brown leaves just beside your right foot. Thick body. Broad, triangular head. Its pattern melts into the leaf litter so completely that one more step and you'd have been on it. It's a lancehead, the most common viper in the Amazon, and by day this is where they usually lie: coiled on the forest floor, among the leaves.

You don't move. It doesn't move.

Pieces of the lodge's safety talk come back to you. Don't cut a bite. Don't try to suck the venom out, whatever the films show. Never tie anything tight around it. Keep still, and get to help fast. Keep still, and be carried out.

Out here, there's nobody to carry you.

Very slowly, you lift your foot and step back. And again. And again, until there are a few metres of forest between you.

When you start walking again, everything is different. Every step gets tested. Every patch of leaves gets a long stare before your foot goes down. A root that looks too much like a coil stops you dead. It's the right instinct, and it's slow. By the time your heart settles, the light has shifted, and you've lost an hour you can't get back.

[B08]

By early afternoon, the bottle is empty and the rain has stopped.

Thirst is a strange thing in a place this wet. Water drips from everything. Your clothes are full of it. And your mouth is dry.

In a hollow between two roots, you find a pool. It's clear. You can see the leaves at the bottom. It looks cleaner than the rainwater did.

You kneel down beside it, and you don't drink.

Clear doesn't mean safe. You can't tell what's in water by looking at it, or smelling it, or tasting it. And you have no fire, so you can't boil it.

The rain wasn't guaranteed safe either, and you know it. It just came down fresh instead of sitting on the forest floor. One mouthful of the wrong water could make you sick out here, a long way from help.

You stand up, thirstier than before, and keep walking.

[B09]

Late in the afternoon, with the light starting to thin, you see it ahead of you: a sapling bent over, its pale inside showing.

Then another one, a few steps beyond it.

You stop and stare, and for a few seconds your brain refuses to understand what your eyes are telling it.

You snapped that. That's yours.

You've been walking toward your own trail. All day you've been going straight, or what felt like straight, and you've curved right back across your own path without ever feeling the turn.

This isn't carelessness. It's how people work. In a study in Germany, people tried to walk a straight line through a forest. When the sun was out, they kept a straight line. When clouds hid the sun, they walked in circles without even noticing. Without the sun or a distant landmark to steer by, small errors in our sense of direction keep adding up, and "straight ahead" slowly bends.

You look up. Above you, the canopy blocks almost all of the sun. There's no sun to steer by. There hasn't been all day.

All that confidence this morning, every step of it, was a curve.

[B10]

You sit down on a root, and for a while you don't do anything at all.

Search and rescue advice for lost people is simple: stop. Stay put. A person who keeps wandering makes the search area bigger and the search slower. That advice works when someone is looking for you. Someone probably is, but you don't know where they're looking, and you don't even know which direction the lodge is.

And waiting isn't free. The shin feels hotter than it did this morning. Your feet ache from the wet.

So you make a different kind of plan. One that doesn't rely on your sense of direction, because your sense of direction has just been caught lying.

Water runs downhill. Small streams run into bigger ones. And the lodge sits on a river. The same kind of advice that says stop also says that if you really do have to move, following a stream or river can often lead you to people.

But not now, not with the light going. Tonight, you rest and save your strength. At first light, you go downhill until you find running water. Then you follow it the way it flows. No more guessing. No more wandering. If you move again, you move with a method.

[B11]

The second night is longer than the first.

Rain comes again, and you fill the bottle again. The mosquitoes find you again. The shin throbs in time with your heartbeat, hot even in the warm, wet dark.

And the jaguar comes back. This time it doesn't even need a sound. Every time a branch shifts, it's out there in the black, and you're sure of it. You're too tired to argue with it. You sit with your back against your tree and let your heart race, and wait for the fear to pass, and it doesn't.

You think about this morning. How sure you were. Every snapped sapling, a little marker on a curve you couldn't feel. The plan for tomorrow is simple: downhill, water, follow it. You turn it over and over in the dark, looking for the flaw.

At some point the rain stops. The insects don't. You hold on to one thought, first light, and you hold on to it until the dark starts, very slowly, to turn green.

[B12]

At first light, you go downhill.

It's slow. The slope is slick, and you go down some of it sitting. But the ground keeps falling away, and after a while you hear it, a low steady trickle, and then you see it. A stream, brown and quick, no wider than a road lane.

You follow it.

Where the banks are tangled, you step down into the water and wade. Your feet have been wet for about two days now. Every step sends a sharp, raw ache up through your soles, and you start counting steps just to keep going.

Around mid-morning you stop to look at the shin, and this time there's no question. The redness has spread well beyond the edges of the cut. The skin around it is hot and tight and swollen, and the strip of sleeve is stuck to something cloudy and yellow. It hurts more than it did yesterday, a deep, pulsing hurt.

The bottle is empty. There's no rain. There's no fire.

You stand there looking at the stream. Then you fill the bottle and drink. You know it's a risk. Thirst is a risk too, and right now it's the more certain one.

[B13]

The stream gets wider. The banks open out. The light changes, first to a paler green, then gold, and then, suddenly, open sky.

You step out of the trees onto a muddy bank, and in front of you is a river. Broad, brown, slow. The sun is on your face for the first time in two days.

Every part of you wants to crawl back into the shade and lie down. You don't. You stay out on the open bank where you can be seen, because that's the whole point of being here.

[B13a]

Then you hear it. An engine.

A boat comes up the river, out on the far side, two people in it watching the opposite bank. You stagger to the edge of the water and wave both arms. You shout, and what comes out is a croak. The boat keeps going. You watch it shrink and slide around the bend upriver, and the sound of the engine fades back into the insects.

The shade at the edge of the trees has never looked so good.

You stay where you are, out on the open mud, in the sun, where anyone on the water could see you. You sit down so you don't fall down. And you wait.

[B14]

The light is low and orange when you hear the buzz again, coming back down the river.

The same boat rounds the bend, on your side this time, slow, close to the bank, two people scanning the trees.

You get up. You wave both arms. You shout with whatever's left of your voice. It comes out as a croak, but you keep doing it, waving and croaking, until one of the figures points and the boat swings toward you.

[B15]

They pull you in. Someone gives you water from a sealed bottle and you drink it too fast and cough.

The boat turns downstream. One bend. That's it. One bend in the river, and there's the dock, and the dining hall, and the boats you saw on the first evening.

The guide at the tiller looks back at the mouth of your stream, then at you.

"Less than a kilometre," he says. About half a mile.

They couldn't search the forest in the dark, he tells you, so they started the morning after you disappeared. Up and down the loop trail, calling your name, all day and all of the next. You never heard a thing. Voices don't carry far under those trees, not over the insects and the rain. And all that time, you were walking in silence, snapping saplings, sure you were heading out. Never more than about a kilometre from the path.

You ask about the crashing in the undergrowth, the thing you ran from. He shrugs. "Could have been peccaries." Pig-like animals that move through the forest in herds and want nothing to do with people.

You think about that for a long time.

[B16]

At the lodge, a doctor cleans the cut and starts you on antibiotics. Your feet take days to recover.

Some risks follow you home. Leptospirosis, from water contaminated by animal urine, can get in through a cut and show up as late as a month afterwards. Malaria from those mosquito bites can take weeks to appear, sometimes months. So for a year, any fever means getting help fast.

The jaguar was always the long shot: about one recorded attack on people a year, across the whole Brazilian Amazon. It never touched you. Running from it is what did the damage.

If you're ever lost, stop first. Stay where you can be found, if anyone knows where to look. And if you have to move, don't trust "straight". Follow something that can't drift, like a stream.

Twenty minutes. That's how long the walk was supposed to take.

The jungle didn't trap you. Your senses did.